

Is AI ACTUALLY bad for environment?

Posted by u/PeepsWeeps • 0 points • 17 comments

Is AI actually as bad for the environment as everybody is claiming? As I research I find studies that claim it IS, but nothing specifically or why. I've heard people claim so much as to say that AI wastes / destroys our water, causes increased global warming, or even will cause us to destroy our ozone layer. In my perspective, it doesn't make much sense to me that just a data server could cause so much destruction environmentally to our planet. If it is actually bad for the environment, at what scale? How much will it affect us both short and long term and is it actually as bad as people say? Or does it make no real difference and when you factor in other pollution / environmentally harmful things humans also do, is it that significant to cause us any real harm that we wouldn't have otherwise?

Comments

u/DiogenesKuon • 1 points • 2025-11-26 17:36 UTC

It uses a lot of energy, but the effects are pretty massively overstated. A chatGPT query takes about as much energy as a single light bulb lit for 30 seconds. A lot of things take a lot of energy and the only question is are we getting value out of that energy use. And we are in a weird Schrodinger's AI place where people think AI is a useless hallucination machine that is also about to steal all of our jobs. If we aren't getting value out of it, then it's a waste of energy, and if we aren't getting value out of it people will stop using it.

u/NoStupidQuestionsBot • 1 points • 2025-11-26 17:07 UTC

Thanks for your submission /u/PeepsWeeps, but it has been removed for the following reason:

****Rule 2: Please try to use the search function before posting anything.****

Thanks for posting, but this question happens to be one that has been asked and answered here often before - sometimes in the same day! That can get frustrating for our dedicated users who like to answer questions. Or maybe you're just asking the same question too often - why not take a break for a while?

Sometimes questions that come up too often get put in our [Most Frequently Asked Questions list] (<https://www.reddit.com/r/NoStupidQuestions/wiki/index/faq/>). Other times, it may just be that we're getting a flood of questions about a topic (especially when something is in the news). Or maybe you keep asking the same question again and again - something that annoys our users here. Please don't do that! Next time, please try searching for your question first before asking. Thanks!

This action was performed by a bot at the explicit direction of a human. This was not an automated action, but a conscious decision by a sapient life form charged with moderating this sub.

If you feel this was in error, or need more clarification, please don't hesitate to [message the moderators](<http://www.reddit.com/message/compose?to=%2Fr%2FNoStupidQuestions>). Thanks.

u/Remodiant • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:58 UTC

It does use a lot of energy and fresh water. But if you meant AI is especially more harmful to the environment compared to other industries, not so much. Almost every industries that make up our society consumes a lot of energy and makes lots of waste.

The reason AI is more blamed than other industries is because many people hate AI for other reasons like AI slops, threat for jobs, copyright problems, etc. The environmental harm is just another addition to it, not the primary reason in most cases.

u/bangbangracer • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:57 UTC

Just on the energy consumption alone, yeah.

u/xb4r7x • 3 points • 2025-11-26 16:53 UTC

It uses a lot of energy, just like all modern computing does, but there have certainly been some seriously sensational arguments being made that are just outright wrong.

Like, a single text prompt on ChatGPT does not use "gallons" of water, like I've heard a lot of people claim.

<https://open.spotify.com/episode/3yNgnYgjTUAk5VkOLCncr#login>

u/TheGanzor • 3 points • 2025-11-26 16:48 UTC

It uses a lot of energy. So does driving. And eating. And wearing clothes. And using paper products. And using plastic products. And using metal products. All of those resources need to be extracted, refined, converted and transported. Everything we do 'costs' something from the environment. That's just entropy.

u/LurkyRabbit • 2 points • 2025-11-26 16:48 UTC

I think the misinformation is more like I've seen people on tiktok say every question you ask AI uses like 45 bottles of water which isn't true lol.

It does use water for cooling, but there's a lot of misinformation about the amount of water every request makes. It certainly does use a ton of water to power the amount of datacenters there are though which is a problem for sure.

Not because we will "run out of water" but because when you evaporate water, there's usually a lot of waste that gets dumped back into the ecosystem which causes problems.

u/Significant_Web4001 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:47 UTC

Is there a way to harness the heat given off from these centers? Like if we transfer that energy to water and create steam that could be basis to run other machines?

u/III-Ad-2452 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:46 UTC

AI takes energy. energy creates heat. water is needed to cool the heat.

So extra energy is being used, earth is being heated more (we already know that's a problem) and we are losing water resources to the cooling.

u/No_Nectarine6942 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:46 UTC

I'd say the building materials, energy costs, how things are processed making the systems and operating it could be detrimental to the environment.

u/CaptainsFolly • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:44 UTC

It uses a ton of energy

u/Lonestarsportsdigest • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:43 UTC

As far as I understand it is the energy and electricity that is needed that is really the issue. AI needs huge amounts of computing power which in turn needs all that electricity. How we can generate that amount of power without damage to the environment on demand has been an issue for awhile and while we have made strides, it has certainly not been solved in any definite way.

u/pan_anu • 9 points • 2025-11-26 16:42 UTC

It's ultra energy-consuming

u/ArrowTaker101 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:41 UTC

I'm admittedly not super knowledgeable, but the way it was explained to me is that it is because AI uses a lot of power. There are thousands of super computers on and running 24/7 that house the AI and their data banks, which suck up that much energy and water (for cooling).

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-11-26 16:40 UTC

[removed]

u/iamofnohelp • 9 points • 2025-11-26 16:40 UTC

AI requires a lot of computing power.

Computers generate a lot of heat that needs to be chilled by water.

u/sterlingphoenix • 10 points • 2025-11-26 16:39 UTC

You know how we were actually making strides in reducing carbon emissions? Well, forget that, we need all the coal plants to run all the datacenters to power all the generative AI stuff.

We're adding _insane_ amounts of computers and datacenters, all of which need more power, more water for cooling, more tons of resources.

u/Bushpylot • 5 points • 2025-11-26 16:43 UTC

More power and more cooling. There goes all that fresh water